

Action Plan

Action Steps

Here are some suggestions for possible action you could take toward your goals. Feel free to change, add, or remove any action steps from this list.

Prayerful Decision-Making, Alignment, and Exploring Your Options Together

1. **Consider using some or all of the DECA Steps as you enter into intentional prayer, evaluation, and decision-making.** This framework helps slow the process down so you can think clearly, express emotions honestly, and make decisions wisely together. At minimum, you want to identify your goals, possible problems, and possible solutions from each of your perspectives.

D	Step 1: Describe your situation	Question: What is the situation?
	Step 2: Determine your goals	Question: What are your goals?
	Step 3: Define your problems tentatively	Question: What problems could be here?
E	Step 4: Express your emotions and feelings	Question: What emotions or feelings need to be expressed?
	Step 5: Explore possible solutions	Question: What solutions could help?
	Step 6: Evaluate pros & cons of the best solutions	Questions: What are the best solutions? What are the pros and cons of each?
C	Step 7: Choose a solution to try	Question: What solution do you want to try?
	Step 8: Create an action plan	Question: What action steps could you take?
	Step 9: Check on progress periodically	Question: What progress has been made?
A	Step 10: Adjust solutions and action steps as necessary	Question: What needs to be adjusted or changed?
	Step 11: Acknowledge and celebrate progress and completed goals.	Question: What can you acknowledge and celebrate?
	Step 12: Allow yourself to go back to Step 1 if you get stuck	Questions: Are you stuck? Could you go back to Step 1 (or another other step)?

D — Describe and Define

- **Step 1: Describe your situation**
Question: *What is the situation?*
- **Step 2: Determine your goals**
Question: *What are your goals?*
- **Step 3: Define your problems tentatively**
Question: *What problems could be here?*
(Tentatively means you are identifying possibilities without assuming you fully understand everything yet.)

E — Express and Explore

- **Step 4: Express your emotions and feelings**
Question: *What emotions or feelings need to be expressed?*

- **Step 5: Explore possible solutions**
Question: *What solutions could help?*
- **Step 6: Evaluate the pros and cons of the best solutions**
Questions: *What are the best solutions? What are the pros and cons of each?*

C — Choose and Create

- **Step 7: Choose a solution to try**
Question: *What solution do you want to try?*
- **Step 8: Create an action plan**
Question: *What action steps could you take?*
- **Step 9: Check on progress periodically**
Question: *What progress has been made?*

A — Adjust and Acknowledge

- **Step 10: Adjust solutions and action steps as necessary**
Question: *What needs to be adjusted or changed?*
- **Step 11: Acknowledge and celebrate progress and completed goals**
Question: *What can you acknowledge and celebrate?*
- **Step 12: Allow yourself to go back to Step 1 if you get stuck**
Questions: *Are you stuck? Can you go back to Step 1 or another step?*

2. If possible, identify the different options and write out the pros and cons together. It is important not only to say the pros and cons out loud, but to physically write or type them out. Writing slows your thinking down and helps you process the emotional charge connected to the decision. This gives both your mind and emotions a chance to be heard and evaluated more clearly.

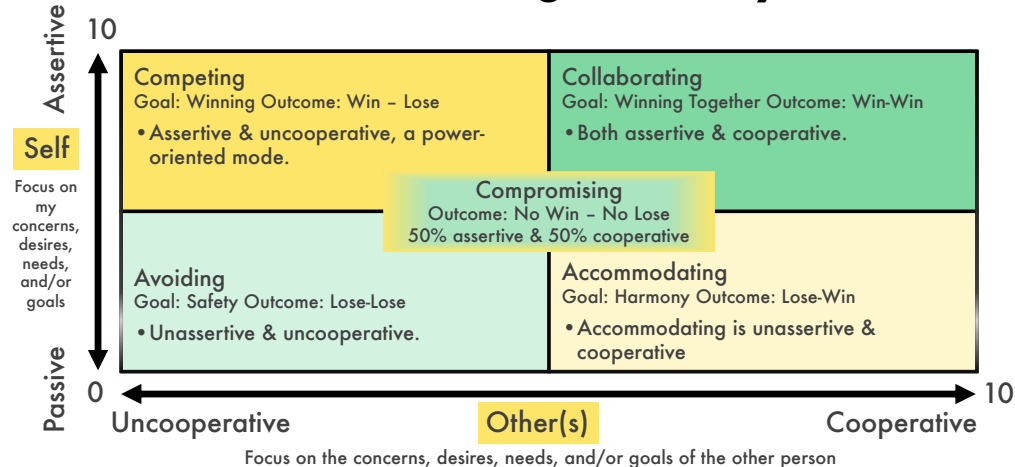
3. After evaluating the pros and cons, give yourselves permission to honestly state your preferences and run thought experiments on each option. Some examples you mentioned were:

- Focusing on your two boys
- Having a biological baby girl or boy
- Adopting a baby girl or boy

Please do not feel guilty for having preferences. Preferences are normal and necessary. Acknowledging a preference does not automatically determine the decision—it simply gives clarity about what your heart is experiencing. Once those preferences are named, you can prayerfully evaluate them together without shame or pressure.

4. **Acknowledge what conflict management styles each of you may be using throughout this process.** As the importance of a decision increases, the level of intentionality needed also increases.

Conflict Management Styles



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Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument by Kenneth W. Thomas and Ralph H. Kilmann (2007) by CPP.

Peter Piñón, 2026

You want to avoid:

- Competing against each other (Win/Lose)
- Avoiding the issue entirely
- Over-accommodating without honesty

At minimum, you want to aim for a **Compromising Style** (meeting in the middle), but ideally a **Collaborating Style** (working together toward a Win/Win solution) if possible. Collaboration takes more time, honesty, patience, and emotional safety, but it often leads to the healthiest long-term outcomes.

5. **Run some behavioral experiments involving three kids if possible.** A behavioral experiment is a practical way to gather real-life data instead of only imagining scenarios in your mind. This could involve helping with or watching three children for anywhere from 4–24 hours in a neutral environment where you do not feel trapped or obligated. The goal is not to perfectly simulate parenting three kids, but to gather emotional, relational, physical, and logistical data to help inform your decision-making.
6. **If you still do not have alignment after a season of processing, consider intentionally revisiting the conversation later.** Instead of forcing resolution prematurely, you can schedule another focused conversation in 6–12 months and reevaluate the situation with new information and experiences. Sometimes clarity develops over time as emotions settle, circumstances change, and more data is collected.